

# BA 336U

## Essentials of Information Technology

The School of Business

PORTLAND STATE UNIVERSITY

# What is BA336?

- **Information Systems: The Big Picture**
  - Use of technology to manage data, improve processes, and support decision-making
  - Business processes made possible by enterprise tools like ERP's, CRM's, and databases
  - How people, processes, and IT work together
- **Excel: Your Toolkit for Insight**
  - Skills in Excel to analyze and present data.
  - Basic functions, formulas, charts, and intermediate tools like PivotTables and lookup functions
  - How businesses make data-informed decisions
- **Information Technology: The Infrastructure**
  - The hardware and software backbone that supports Information Systems.
  - Networks, security, cloud computing, and databases.
  - Emerging technologies (e.g., AI, Blockchain, quantum computing) and how they shape today's businesses.



# Do I Have to Be Here...or...Digital Literacy For the Real World




- Digital literacy
  - Understand, use, and communicate with data and in a business context (no coding required)
- Seeing through the lens of a manager
  - Understand how managers use, and communicate with data and technology in a business context
- Not just button pushing
  - Excel is a tool. Use it to uncover insights and drive decisions.
- Translating technology into business
  - Connect the "what" of technology with the "why" of business impact
- Because your future coworkers will thank you
  - Data skills make you credible and valuable

# Who Is This Class For?

- Beginners (never used Excel, no plans to be an executive)
- Intermediate users (want to go beyond basic functions, understand managerial lens)
- Advanced users (students applying Excel in real-world contexts, realize they may have to manage a team one day)



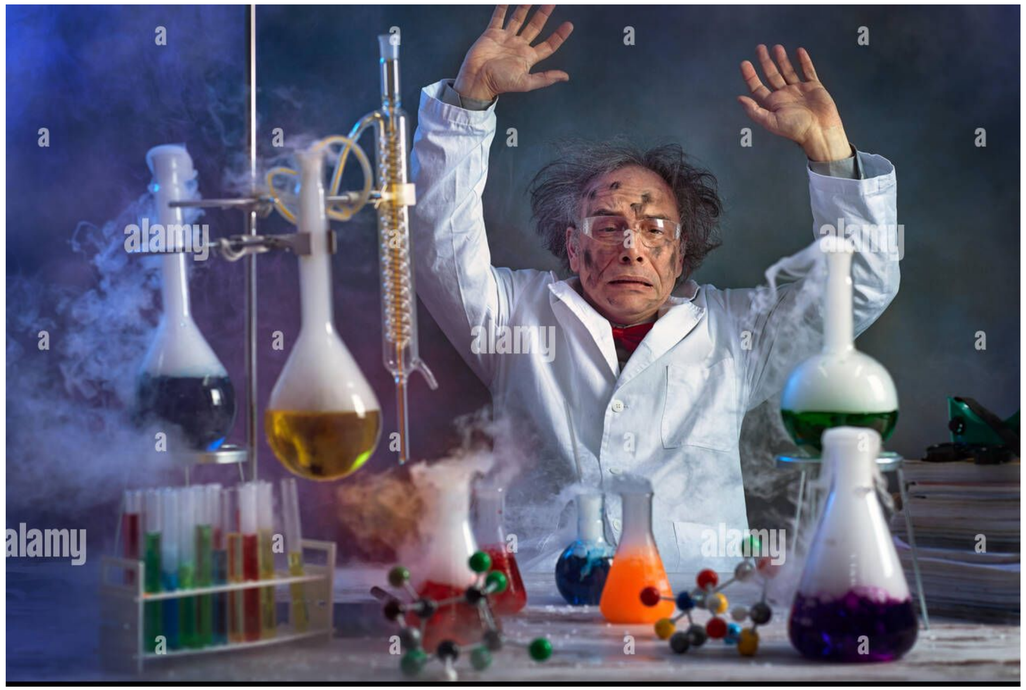
# Creativity is a Career Advantage

- The world needs creativity
- Business isn't the opposite of creativity, it’s another application of it
- Real-world jobs use storytelling, empathy, design, and experimentation
- Creative skills are powerful in industry
- This class teaches tools that open doors



# *Real Job Titles Using Skills from BA336*

| Job Title | Avg. Salary (Portland) | Sample Job Functions |
|---|---|---|
| Business Analyst | $65K–$95K | Dashboards, scenario modeling |
| Digital Marketing Analyst | $60K–$85K | Data from campaigns, Excel & web analytics |
| Entry-Level Data Analyst | $60K–$90K | Pivot tables, visualizing data, light SQL |
| Operations Coordinator | $50K–$65K | Tracking performance, managing data in Excel |
| Customer Success Specialist | $60K–$90K | CRM tools, Excel reports on retention/engagement |
| Account Manager | $55-$85k | Onboard new customers, maintain relationships, build reports for customers, Excel or Sheets |




# How We'll Work Together

- Weekly class sessions (in-person or online)
  - Stay engaged and connected as we explore key topics.
- Curiosity is required
  - Connect course concepts to current events, tech news, and the world around you.
- Inquiry over memorization
  - Ask questions

    Explore real-world examples  and challenge assumptions.
- Focus on applied learning
  - Doing, not testing
  - Hands-on practice over multiple-choice exams.

# What Next

- Start right away
  - Dive into the first Excel module. Get familiar with the course site.
- Ask for help early
  - Don’t wait. Reach out if you hit a snag. I’m here, and so are your classmates.
- Build connections
  - Whether in person or online, this class works better when you talk, share, and collaborate.
- If you’re new to this, stay positive.
  - Struggle is inevitable. It’s where the real learning happens



# The End

- Go forth and automate responsibly

